

Evidence

We were all lined up in a row
along the side of the highway:

RV
leaning hard over the edge of the shoulder
passenger-side wheel torn to shreds
wires and gas lines tangled in rubber
totaled

Flatbed tow truck
dwarfing our little camper
driver vaping, yelling into his phone

A newly dead cedar waxwing
pressed into the asphalt
soft brown head intact, beak open
looking up to the left
wings spread out and down
no blood
just red-tipped feathers,
tiny tangled feet

My feet in flipflops
dirty from hours on the roadside
almost touching the bird
squatting down to look closer
left knee burning when I put my full weight on it
axle grease on my hands from trying to change the tire.
I touch a yellow tailfeather.
It yields to me immediately.

The family car
shuddering in the heat
listless kids, wrappers on the floor
husband on the phone with insurance
wife in the passenger seat
stray wires caught up in her pant leg
a ziplock bag of feathers in her hand

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